

Dromaeosaurs

The dromaeosaurs were small but ferocious hunters with bladelike teeth and vicious, hooked claws on their hands and feet. They were closely related to birds and may have evolved from a flying ancestor. Their long arms folded up like wings, and their bodies were fully feathered. Dromaeosaurs are sometimes also called “raptors,” a word that means “thief” or “grabber.”

Dromaeosaurus

DROM-ee-oh-SORE-us



- **When** 75 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Canada
- **Habitat** Forests, plains
- **Length** 6½ ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Flesh

Dromaeosaurus
skull



About the size of *Velociraptor*, *Dromaeosaurus* had a stockier skull and a deeper lower jaw, suggesting it had a more powerful bite. It had large eyes and hunted by vision, perhaps stalking prey quietly like a cat does before leaping for the kill. Only a partial skull and a few bones of *Dromaeosaurus* have been found. The skeleton shown below is based on these and other closely related dromaeosaurs.

Dromaeosaurus
reconstruction

Utahraptor

YOU-tah-RAP-tor



- **When** 130–120 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 23 ft (7 m)
- **Diet** Flesh

Utahraptor was the largest dromaeosaur and reached about half a ton in weight, making it heavier than a grizzly bear. Like other dromaeosaurs, it had a large, hooked claw on its second toe that it might have used for slashing or stabbing a victim after leaping on it. One fossilized claw measures 9 in (24 cm) in length.



Toe claw

Long arms

Three clawed
fingers on each
hand

Toe claw